

later). FORTRAN was written for the IBM 704 by a team led by John Backus (one of the inventors of the Backus-Naur Form). It was long the language of choice for the scientific and engineering community, with applications in many areas like weather forecasting, computational fluid dynamics, quantum chromodynamics, and other tasks where supercomputers are used. Some benchmarks for computer processors are still written in FORTRAN. The language is scheduled for another revision in 2008.

Ancient Computing?

The Backus Naur form is a formal method of defining the structure of languages, especially computer languages. It has many similarities to Panini's rules for Sanskrit grammar. It was first introduced in 1959.

September: CERN established

CERN (European Organisation for Nuclear Research, French: Organisation européenne pour la recherche nucléaire) was established in September by 12 European states. It was dedicated to nuclear research and particle physics, though later on it had important influences in the world of computing. It was a pioneer



The CERN logo

in introducing the Internet to Europe in the 1980s, while the World Wide Web was the result of a CERN project in 1991.

December: The first commercial mass-produced computer

The IBM 650, also known as the Magnetic Drum Calculator, was released. It was the first mass-produced computer designed for commercial use. In nine years of manufacture, IBM sold 2,000 650s. It used magnetic drum memory for storage, and was compatible with punch card readers. The 650 used a table look-up feature, along with error checking capabilities, which made it suitable for insurance companies, public utility companies, and transport companies to calculate bills. It was the most popular computer of the 1950s.